

Why Waiting is Worth It

A GRAMMAR OF AGENCY

Moral Action in an Age of Artificial Intelligence

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Preface

This capstone concludes three years of formation with the Lay Mission Institute and a small circle cohort in Danville, California and takes its name in deliberate dialogue with St. John Henry Newman's *Grammar of Assent*. Newman argued that real certitude arises not from mechanical inference (mere syllogistic logic applied) but from the convergence of interior faculties — a unity of mind, will, and perception - an interior integrity across domains. The *Grammar of Agency* stands on the same ground: that moral action, like assent, is not a mechanical output but a disciplined interior event. Where Newman traced the epistemic movement toward truth, this work traces the moral movement toward the good.

I can't possibly thank all of those involved in the preparation of this document, but without my Lay Mission disciple group out of St. Isidore's parish in Danville, California and my fellow brothers and sisters at St. Albert the Great's Lay Dominican Fraternity in Oakland, this would not have been possible. For all involved, I am deeply and eternally grateful. This is offered as seed to be spread.

Introduction

We live in a socially mediated, post-modern world increasingly saturated by generative artificial intelligence. More and more of our decisions—our opportunities to exercise judgment and our freedom for excellence—are quietly outsourced to the machine. The danger is not that the machine becomes a ghost in a shell; it is that the human becomes a hollow shell, having surrendered the work of her own soul. This essay argues that in a culture cascading toward speed at all costs, where immediate utility outruns truth evaluation, both tradition and revelation insist on a different rhythm: a pause that allows reason to lead before action.

Human beings, created in the image and likeness of God, are set apart by reason—by the capacity to see and choose the good. Rightly ordered passions, shaped through virtues such as prudence, temperance, and fortitude, form the conditions for sound judgment. Yet judgment cannot be rushed and still remain sound. GenAI generates fluent, plausible output at speeds that invite shortcuts. The temptation is to replace the slow work of judgment with the rapid appearance of productivity.

A recent California Court of Appeal episode illustrates the danger. In *Torres*,¹ a client saw a case mentioned on Reddit and relayed it to her attorney. He cited it in a pleading. The court accepted the argument, directed opposing counsel to draft an order, and entered it. Not one person in that chain verified the citation. The case did not exist. Everyone relied on someone else—or something else—

¹ *In re the Domestic Partnership of Joan Pablo Torres Campos* (March 5, 2026, California Court of Appeal, Fourth Appellate District, No. D085584)

to have done the checking. The fundamental roles of Agent and Witness were abandoned in favor of an external Influencer: a GenAI-mediated rumor.

This failure was not inevitable. It takes less than a minute to place a citation into a free legal database, verify its existence, and read the case. And yet no one performed that essential craftwork of the legal profession—the first lesson of the first year: look it up, read it, reason about it. Do not outsource your judgment.

The Grammar of Agency seeks to provide a structure that embeds the habits necessary to reclaim that judgment. Its keel—the stabilizing beam—is Revelation, Tradition, and Practice: the bedrock of Catholic Social Teaching. Through this fourfold lens we evaluate any act: Does it restore human dignity? Does it seed the common good? Does it cultivate solidarity? Does it uplift the little ones?

This grammar belongs to every human being, because agency is not a professional skill but a universal dignity—rooted in the image of God and shared equally across age, class, culture, and capacity.

Once anchored in the keel, the Grammar proceeds through a four-step kata, with a necessary pause between the third and fourth steps. Step one is Frame—attend to yourself and the situation. Step two is Receive and Sense—see reality as it is, not as you wish it to be. Step three is Orient and Align—integrate what you have perceived with the keel of core values. Then comes the prudential pause: the wu wei, the steeping of the tea. Only then do we reach step four: Act and Iterate. We call this kata JPP—Judgment-Premised Processing.

This essay outlines the keel and the kata, provides case studies, and offers a glossary of terms to ensure clarity of use. Its thesis is simple: waiting is worth it. The time taken allows reason—our shared participation in the mind of the Creator—to have its rightful place in the process, rather than being outsourced to something not made in the image of God.

This grammar stands within a long lineage—from Aristotle’s naming and framing of good, goals and meaning, to Aquinas’ interior act, to Catherine’s movement from cell to bridge to force through fire, to Pinckaers’ freedom for excellence to become who we were meant to be, to John Paul II’s personalism and persistence to Leo XIII’s social doctrine and telling truth to power—because agency presents as virtue in motion. Virtue based on a disposition formed to move to the good.

Yet the problem does not remain at the level of isolated professional failures. It descends inward, slowly reshaping the interior architecture of desire, attention, and self-governance. What begins as convenience becomes erosion; what looks like personalization becomes curation; what feels like assistance becomes replacement. Bit by bit, capacities once belonging to the human soul alone are handed to systems built to optimize utility, not virtue — to make *us* more efficient, not freer.

Ultimately, to cite Fr. Servais Pinckaers, O.P., our freedom for excellence, not to do whatever we feel like, but to do what we were meant to do, move purposefully along the path to sainthood.²

And it's free — or so we tell ourselves. Free, even as our desires and micro-behaviors are quietly siphoned away, coalescing into a *myst* — that fog rolling in by degrees, sensed, smelt, felt, subtly reforming us and returning as persuasion. Ever say something aloud only to watch it appear in your feed? Free, right.

So we must ask honestly: Are our desires still our own? Is there any interior space left untouched? Or, in the name of efficiency, have we already surrendered that too?

Myst – let's define that sensation one experiences around midnight by the Embarcadero in San Francisco with the fog rolling in, the ambient lights sparkling in a dissipated humid and heavy haze - *myst*.

Yet nothing essential is lost beyond recovery; the human capacity for judgment, presence, and love can be restored, because the soul is not a machine and cannot be hollowed beyond the reach of grace.

The question is no longer whether we will outsource. It is what remains when we have outsourced everything we can. We have ceded capacities to machines. We are also slowly ceding ourselves — the Witness Moment³, the interiority necessary for discernment, for purposeful action. Bit by bit we've outsourced the skills we once possessed — and thus, voluntarily, lost — and, accordingly, maybe without realizing it, ceded our very agency, our autonomy, our freedom for excellence. What we are outsourcing, almost without noticing, is the very judgment by which we once governed ourselves.

At some point, the outsourcing must stop. And it must stop with us — with an interior stance, a posture of agency: I will not offload my moral responsibility to the machine. AI cannot parse a moral plane. Its outputs have form without substance, fluency without accountability. An AI response is not an act. It does not relate to the real world; it receives input and produces output. It does not stand before the good. It does not choose. This capstone argues that the only stable response to an

² Servais Pinckaers, O.P., *Morality: The Catholic View* (South Bend: 2001, St. Augustine's Press, translated by Michael Sherwin, O.P.)(freedom of excellence is contrasted with freedom of indifference, the whatever of the post-modern paradigm)

³ The Witness Moment is where an act of a human becomes a morally laden human act, where the person's action is intentional, has meaning and involves three relations: that acting Agent, the Influencer(s) and the tertiary Witness. It is when the Act enters the Field, the sequence is revealed in the Taffy Toss, described below.

automated age is the deliberate formation of human agency through a structural architecture that unites virtue, timing, and presence.

"But I trust my phone," someone might say. "I use it every day." Fair enough. But what about your car? Increasingly, people allow their vehicles to drive themselves while they sit back, perhaps paying attention, perhaps not. When the system misses something and someone is harmed, who is responsible? The machine processed the data. The machine issued the command. The machine executed the maneuver. Is that an act?

Not in the Thomistic sense of *actus* of a human agent. The driver initiated the sequence, set the *telos*, and surrendered vigilance. If you start the ball rolling, are you not responsible for the avalanche that follows?

This is the field we now inhabit — a moral landscape in which artificial systems perform more of the tasks that once required human judgment, attention, and will. The Grammar of Agency is an attempt to name that field, to map its contours, and to recover the distinctly human capacity for intentional, virtuous action within it.

This capstone begins with a simple claim: *in an age of artificial intelligence, the most urgent task is the formation of human agency.*

Not information transfer. Not technique acquisition. Formation — the slow, deliberate, habituated shaping of the moral person so that when the moment arrives, the right act arises not from calculation but from character. This is what the Dominican tradition has always understood. This is what the Lay Mission Institute exists to transmit. And this is what no artificial intelligence, however fluent, however fast, however vast its training, can either perform or replace.

The Mechanism of Displacement

The problem of agency in an AI age is not simply that machines now do things humans once did. It is that the outsourcing of cognitive and moral tasks does not leave the human agent intact and merely unburdened. It reshapes the agent. When navigation is permanently delegated to GPS, spatial reasoning does not merely rest — it atrophies. When a recommendation engine curates every cultural encounter, the capacity for self-directed attention contracts. The loss is not the skill itself but the interior architecture that the skill required and sustained: the habit of judgment, the tolerance for ambiguity, the willingness to be wrong and correct course.

This is the specific mechanism by which AI degrades moral agency — not through malice or design, but through the logic of optimization itself. A system optimized to minimize friction in decision-making will, over time, minimize the decision-maker. It will anticipate before the agent has framed the question, recommend before the agent has sensed the field, and execute before the agent has oriented toward the good. The four moves of JPP — Frame, Receive and Sense, Orient and Align, Act and Integrate — are not merely bypassed. They are made to feel unnecessary. And what feels unnecessary, we stop practicing. What we stop practicing; we lose the ability to perform.

The structural architecture that the *Grammar of Agency* proposes in response is a metaphor representing a process: a ship of state in which the moral agent is not a passenger but the operator — steering stable in a chaotic world through the fusion of judgment and making with (*Con+Facere*),

held on course by the keel of revelation, tradition and practice which provide a foundation for cardinal virtues on the horizontal plan of proportion and relation, stabilized vertically by the transcendent virtues of Faith, Hope, and Love, and timed by *wu wei*. The spinning top is gyroscopic stability. The yoke-harness is the interface between human agency and the field. The rudder is prudential judgment in motion. These elements are elaborated in the sections that follow. The problem of agency is the problem of maintaining all of them simultaneously, underload in a world designed to make each one feel optional. Where each virtue and the timing of practice is slowly stripped away until all that is left is a mere consumer, or, rather, a data point to influence and monetize.

Section II: The Thomistic Foundation

Conscience as Act, Not Power

To understand why the *Grammar of Agency* makes the claims it does, we must begin where Aquinas begins: with the nature of conscience itself. In the *Summa Theologiae* (I, Q. 79, A. 13), Aquinas asks whether conscience is a power of the soul. His answer is precise and consequential: conscience is not a power but an act — the act of applying knowledge to an individual case. The Latin etymology reveals the architecture: *conscientia*, knowledge held together with, knowledge applied in the moment of encounter. Conscience is *cum alio scientia* — knowledge brought to bear on a particular situation. Thus, for Thomas, conscience is an act (*actus*), not a *habitus*. A moment, not a disposition.

This matters enormously for how we understand moral errors. If conscience were a power — a faculty we simply possess — then moral failure would be a malfunction, a failure of equipment. But Aquinas tells us conscience is an act, which means moral failure is a failure of performance. And performance can be disciplined, trained, habituated. This is the opening through which formation enters.

The *Catechism of the Catholic Church* (§37) reinforces the point from the phenomenological direction. Human reason is genuinely capable of attaining moral truth — but in practice it is hampered at every turn: by the impact of the senses, by the imagination, and above all by disordered appetites. The result is that men easily persuade themselves that what they would not like to be true is instead false or at least doubtful. The easiest lie to believe is the one you want to be true. But, in fact, you know it is not true. That is the seed of disordered will.

This is the diagnostic that the *Grammar of Agency* takes as its starting point: error is rarely about lack of intelligence. It is almost always about disordered will. The intellect is not broken; it is bent by appetite. Formation is the discipline of the will, by practice of the body and prayer of the heart, all of which can produce pain, sorrow and agony. The journey is worth it, it's not just plowing the field, it is leaping with the hinds on the mountains and elevating. Only the vertical virtues of Faith, Hope and Love reside and thrive in that domain of elevation. The horizontal field of optimized specious pulp has no real value without those virtues.

The Two-Axis Model: What AI Can and Cannot Do

The *Grammar of Agency* rests on a two-axis architecture that clarifies precisely what artificial intelligence can simulate and what it cannot enter.

The horizontal axis is the plane of the cardinal virtues: Prudence, Justice, Fortitude, and Temperance. These virtues have definable criteria, measurable distortions, recognizable signatures, and predictable consequences. A large language model can reason about justice with fluency, describe prudent action with precision, model temperance, and advise on fortitude. The horizontal plane is, in a precise sense, LLM-legible. AI lives here naturally and can provide genuine assistance to a human agent navigating this plane.

The vertical axis is the transcendent spine that only a human agent can engage. It is animated by Faith — trust that good is worth pursuing; Hope — orientation toward a redeemable future; and Love — the governing intention toward the dignity of the other. These exceed calculation, cannot be automated, and belong uniquely to the human soul in its capacity for self-transcendence.

AI can describe what a just act looks like. It cannot perform one. It can model temperance with precision. It cannot place the Kind bar and wait. Without the vertical stabilizer, the horizontal plane is merely optimization: fast, fluent, and flat.

A tension worth naming: if AI assistance on the horizontal plane is genuine, the formed agent must approach it with care. An agent whose vertical axis is not engaged may receive AI guidance on prudence or justice as though it were a substitute for the interior act of judgment rather than a prompt toward it. The horizontal help is real. But an agent who outsources the horizontal moves without the vertical axis orienting the whole does not receive assistance — they receive replacement. The two-axis model is not a license for selective delegation; it is a map of what must remain irreducibly human. The vertical axis is not a supplement to the system. It is the condition under which the system is moral at all.

Truth as the Epistemological Ground

Underlying both axes is a prior commitment about the nature of truth itself. Aquinas, in the *Summa Theologiae* (I, Q. 16, A. 6), argues that truth is one in its ground — derived from the single divine intellect by analogy — and many in its reception, instantiated in particular knowing subjects. Many truths are reflected from the one divine truth, as from one face many likenesses are reflected in a mirror.

The implication is foundational: truth is not produced by the human mind. It is received. Conscience is not an authority that invents truth but a faculty that receives, recognizes, and applies it. This establishes the epistemological posture the Grammar of Agency requires: humility. Truth is something we submit to before it is something we use. Formation begins in this submission — in the willingness to be wrong, to be corrected, to receive rather than generate the measure of the good. Truth is received, not produced, thus, formation begins with posture, stance, preparation with the flow of the field.

This stance of humility acknowledges the Creator — we are created, that is our initial presentation into this world. It is relational; the child is borne of a mother, so there are at least two people in the

relationship. Both came into a world that already was there, with meaning, struggles and joy. We are capable of joy in experiencing creation and our place in it. The order, the beauty, the truth. All preexisting our presence. And which will endure when we leave this plane.

Section III: The Grammar in Motion — CST-JPP

The CST Fourfold Test: Altitude Instrument

Catholic Social Teaching, in the *Grammar of Agency*, is not a library of principles to be consulted after the fact. It is an operator's manual for moments — a way of reading the field that gives the agent moral altitude: clarity about what kind of moment they are in and what it is asking of them. The tradition is rendered as four questions, asked before action:

- Does this action restore human dignity?
- Does it seed the garden of the common good?
- Is it sisterly and brotherly — does it strengthen solidarity?
- Does it uplift the little ones?

If the answer is not yes to all four, the action is not yet just. These are not a checklist to be completed and filed. They are an altitude instrument — a continuous reading of the moral field that the agent carries into every situation, mapping directly onto CST's four pillars: human dignity, common good, solidarity, and the preferential option for the poor.

JPP: The Four Moves as Kata – a discipline of practice to instill disposition

Judgment Premised Processing (JPP) is the steering mechanism — a kata for disciplined action when the world is loud and ambiguous. Where CST clarifies what matters, JPP clarifies what to do. It is structured as four moves, repeatable in sequence, forming disposition through praxis:

- **Frame.** Take in the moment. Achieve self-awareness and field awareness simultaneously. Snap in — be fully present to what is actually happening, not what you anticipated or feared.
- **Receive and Sense.** Be actively passive. Open to what the moment is delivering before moving to interpret it. The senses gather; the intellect has not yet formed its judgment. This move requires stillness — the discipline of not rushing to conclusion.
- **Orient and Align.** Frame with purpose and direction. Turn toward the good. Align posture, intention, and proportion. Ask: what is the right act here, for this person, in this moment, given what is at stake?
- *The Space Between: Discernment in the Moment*
- **Act and Integrate.** Now, in this moment, act. Assess and iterate. Stability provides closure: clean, with no ripple left. The act is complete when the field has been met and the agent has returned to readiness.

The kata is portable. It can be run in thirty seconds or thirty minutes. Formation is the work of making the kata reflexive before the high-stakes moment arrives. But between the third and fourth move there is a *threshold* — *the most important and most neglected moment in the entire sequence*.

Wu Wei: The Timing Belt

Between Orient and Align and Act and Integrate there is a threshold. Before naming it, intellectual honesty requires acknowledging where its deepest philosophical roots form: not in 13th-century Paris, but in ancient China, in the classical Taoist tradition, more than nineteen centuries before Thomas Aquinas was born.

Lao Tzu composed the *Tao Te Ching* (道德經) in the 6th century BC, in the Zhou dynasty of ancient China. Its central concern is the nature of the Tao: the Way, the underlying current of reality that cannot be named, only aligned with. And its most demanding practical teaching is *wu wei* — 無為 — the discipline of action that does not force, 非強為” (*fei qiang wei* — *not forced action*).

Wu wei is not passivity. It is not indifference. It is not quietism. It is the discipline of action that does not precede its natural moment — that allows reality to complete its own disclosure before the agent moves to meet it. *Wu wei* is not the virtue; it is the temporal discipline that allows the virtues to operate without distortion.

Thomas Aquinas, writing in 13th-century Paris, arrives at a formulation that resonates powerfully across the nineteen-century gap: prudence as *recta ratio agibilium* — right reason applied to action. Aquinas gives us the rational architecture of right judgment — the what and the why of prudential action. The Tao gives us the temporal wisdom of right timing — when and the how not just yet. And to be prepared, to act when that preparation meets opportunity. Together, what to do and when to do it, they constitute a complete account of moral action that neither tradition achieves alone.

Mantra: Let the tea steep. Gather seeds. Scent tea. Palm seeds. Breathe. Ground.

Mary's Fiat: Prudence In Docile Acceptance

The perfected integration of *wu wei* and *recta ratio agibilium*

In this, our Blessed Mother stands as the clearest human exemplar. Across the **Annunciation**, **Cana**, and **Calvary**, she reveals a single interior stance: not passivity, but formed readiness—prudence perfected in timing.

All three mysteries—**Annunciation**, **Cana**, and **Calvary**—reveal the same interior stance: Mary stands at the threshold between **Orient & Align** and **Act & Integrate** with perfect readiness. At the **Annunciation**, she receives what she does not yet understand, inquires proportionately, holds the moment open, and consents only when discernment has completed its interior work. At **Cana**, she notes the disturbance—“They have no wine”—names the need, prepares the field, and steps back into the timing belt: “Do whatever he tells you.” No forcing, no scripting, only formed readiness. At **Calvary**, she enacts this same posture under maximal load: she stands, present to the horror, grounded in faith and hope wrapped in love, neither collapsing nor attempting to seize control of what cannot be controlled.

In each mystery, Mary embodies the union of temporal *wu wei* and Thomistic right action. She receives, interiorizes, and holds the moment in her heart until the act that is hers to perform becomes clear. And when the moment opens, her action—whether consent, preparation, or

standing fast—is exact, proportionate, and fully aligned with the good. Her stillness is not passivity but the highest form of prudence: disciplined openness to the right act at the right time.

The Silicon Valley Inversion — and Why It Matters Now

The urgency of recovering this ancient, time-tested, and trans-cultural wisdom is specific and contemporary. The dominant culture of technological development — centered in Silicon Valley but now global in its reach and cultural authority — has made a virtue and an economy out of the systematic elimination of the threshold between discernment and action. Move fast and break things. Ship before you're ready. Fail forward. Iterate at speed. Disruption as default posture.

This is *wu wei* inverted. It is not simply the absence of patience — it is the active, culturally enforced destruction of the conditions that make patience possible. The timing belt has not merely been neglected; it has been removed and celebrated in its removal. The threshold between discernment and action — the space between thought and act, that both Aquinas and Lao Tzu recognized as the locus of genuine moral judgment — has been reengineered as inefficiency, as friction, as competitive disadvantage to be eliminated.

The *Grammar of Agency* names this clearly: the elimination of the timing belt is not a competitive advantage. It is a moral failure. And the recovery of *wu wei* — of the active, disciplined restraint that holds the threshold open while discernment completes its work — is not a retreat from the modern world. Taking the time to discern; to let intellect manage will and appetite; is the only path back to agency, autonomy, and authentic human moral action.

The Timing Belt in Practice

In the *Grammar of Agency*, *wu wei* (prudential patience) functions as the timing belt that connects **Orient and Align** to **Act and Integrate**. It is the active discipline of restraint — not the absence of agency but its most refined expression. The agent who has oriented toward the good and aligned with right intention now holds still. Not from paralysis. Not from fear. But from the knowledge that the moment has not yet fully opened, and that premature action is itself a form of distortion.

The mantra that anchors this threshold in practice carries six beats, each one a micro-practice of *wu wei* — of holding the threshold open while discernment completes its interior work:

Let the tea steep. Gather seeds. Scent tea. Palm seeds. Breathe. Ground.

The tea does not steep faster because you are watching it. The seed does not germinate on demand. The moral moment does not open on command. The agent who knows this waits — not passively, but with the active, attentive, disciplined stillness that the Zhuangzi calls the natural posture of the skilled person and that Aquinas calls the patience proper to prudence. This is the timing belt. This is what is missing from Silicon Valley. This is what formation must restore.

The Agent-Influencer-Witness Triad: Relational Geometry

No moral moment is inhabited by one person alone. The *Grammar of Agency* names three roles that are always present, whether or not they are occupied by distinct persons. The **Agent** is the human moral actor who performs the *actus* — who carries the vertical axis and bears sole responsibility for the act. The **Influencer** is any force — person, system, structure, or context — that shapes the field

in which the Agent acts, but does not act in the Agent's place. The algorithm that curates your feed is an Influencer. The community of formation is an Influencer. So is the cultural air of Silicon Valley that makes speed feel virtuous. The **Witness** is the tertiary evaluator who reads the moral vector of the moment — and testifies only when systemic disturbance threatens the Agent's autonomy. When autonomy is intact and the kata is running cleanly, the Witness remains silent. This triad — *Con+Facere*, “to make with” — names the irreducibly communal nature of moral action: the Agent acts, but never alone. Formation is always shared. The Witness Moment is always witnessed.

The Witness Moment: Where the System Proves Itself

Everything in the *Grammar of Agency* converges on a single instant: the **Witness Moment**. This is the *actus* — the decisive, embodied action of the agent — the hinge between intention and consequence, the only moment where agency is real.

Aquinas distinguishes the exterior act — the physical thing done — from the interior act — the choosing, the willing, the orienting toward the good that precedes and animates the exterior act. The **Witness Moment** is the instant when the interior act penetrates the horizontal plane and enters the world. It is where virtue becomes testimony. Where the vertical axis touches the real. Where the timing belt releases and the wind moves the sail.

An AI cannot create a **Witness Moment**. It can process the field. It can describe what a witness moment looks like. It cannot stand in one — because standing requires presence, and presence requires a soul.

Section IV: The Grammar in Action — Case Studies

Theory without demonstration is philosophy. The *Grammar of Agency* makes its strongest claims in concrete moments — in the controlled conditions of a pedagogical exercise and in the wild conditions of real human encounter. The following two case studies demonstrate JPP's operational coherence across distinct domains of formation and encounter.

Case Study 1: The Taffy Toss — The Controlled Demonstration in situ

The Objective Narrative

A seminar room. Thirteen seats arranged around a table, six occupied. The presenter stands at the front. A handout has been distributed. The session on JPP is about to begin.

Without preamble or explanation, the presenter turns away from the audience and reaches for a supply of individually wrapped saltwater taffy — enough for thirteen, though only six are present. He turns back toward the table and tosses the candy across it in a single, generous motion. The taffy scatters freely. There is more than enough. The field is open. Resources are unlimited. Anyone may take as much as they want.

Participants reach for the taffy. They take pieces. Some unwrap one immediately. The atmosphere is informal, easy. The gesture reads as a gift — an opening move of generosity before the work begins.

The presenter turns away again. This time, when he turns back, he holds a single Kind bar. He does not toss it. He does not distribute it. He walks to the table and places it — deliberately, quietly, without comment. He sets it down at the center of the table. He steps back. He says nothing. He waits.

Nobody takes the Kind bar.

The room goes still. Eyes move to the bar, then to the presenter, then back to the bar. Hands that might have reached do not reach. The pause lasts several seconds — longer than is comfortable. Nobody speaks. Nobody takes. Nobody explains why they are not taking.

The exercise is complete.

The Analysis

The taffy toss is the AI operating environment made visible. Unlimited resources across an open field. Relational access, proportionate distribution, instantaneous availability, no moral weight. This is the matrix in which a large language model operates naturally. AI lives permanently in the toss. It cannot do what happens next.

The Kind bar placement is a different category of action entirely. Before the hand moves, something has already happened inside. The presenter has framed the situation, received and sensed the field, oriented and aligned toward a deliberate act — and then held the timing belt. Wu wei between Orient and Act. The threshold honored. The discernment allowed to complete. Only then the placement: deliberate, quiet, without explanation.

Nobody takes the Kind bar because the field changed. The placement introduced a Witness — a human being who acted deliberately, who placed something with intention, who is now present and waiting. The participants feel that presence before their minds can form a thought about it.

The hesitation is the proof that the system is working. It is the most important moment in the exercise — not the toss, not the placement, but the pause in which every person in the room discovers, without being told, that they already know the difference between the two. Formation does not install a new capacity. It cultivates one that was already there, waiting for the moment to call it forward.

The Buddhist March on Petersburg — The Grammar in the Wild

The Field

The Buddhist foot-marchers come in slow and steady, the way only people who've walked a hundred miles can move — not tired, but tuned. Their saffron robes catch the winter sun. Padding alongside them, tail up, is Ashoka, the stray mutt who adopted them somewhere around Dinwiddie and never left.

As they crest the hill into Petersburg, they meet the welcome party: the Methodist pastor with her stole tucked into her coat, the AME choir director holding a thermos of sweet tea, the civic association president with a clipboard he doesn't really need, three teenagers from the local Wicca

circle wearing cloaks they absolutely do need, and a few curious onlookers who just wanted to see the dog.

Inside the old tobacco auction house — now the Farmers Market, its rafters still faintly smelling of cured leaf and history — long tables are already set: cornbread, dal, collards, dumplings, sweet potato pies, and a pot of something spicy that no one can identify but everyone wants to try. The field is warm, open, unguarded.

The Disturbance

Then, from the far corner of the building, comes a sharp voice. A cluster of intellectual agitators has gathered, arms crossed, notebooks out, ready to pounce. "This is syncretism! Buddhism doesn't march with Christians!" Another: "Christianity is being diluted by this ecumenical spectacle!" A third: "Wicca has nothing to do with your peace-march theatrics!"

They are not speaking to the marchers. They are speaking to each other — a closed loop of grievance. But the field wobbles. Not violently. Just enough to feel the tilt.

The Proportionate Responses

What happens next is not planned, not coordinated, not strategic. It is proportionate — each response the product of a formed disposition expressing itself through the timing belt: held just long enough, then released with minimum necessary force.

- The Buddhist monk bows slightly and says: "We walk with whoever walks." No argument. No defense. Just clarity.
- The Methodist pastor steps forward, hands in her pockets: "Hospitality isn't dilution. It's hospitality." She doesn't raise her voice. She doesn't need to.
- The Wiccan teen shrugs: "We're literally just here for the dog." Ashoka wags on cue.
- The AME choir director laughs: "If you think this is syncretism, you've never been to a potluck." The room cracks open with warmth.

The Analysis

None of these responses could have been scripted, optimized, or generated by an AI prompted to "respond to criticism." Each required embodied presence, read context, and moral character formed over time. Each was an actus in the full Thomistic sense. And each carried the signature of wu wei: the brief, unnoticed pause before the response — the timing belt held just long enough for clarity to form — and then the proportionate word, delivered without excess. The field disturbance did not require aggressive correction; it required moral poise.

The horizontal virtues held the plane: temperance in the pastor's quiet voice, justice in the monk's inclusive clarity, fortitude in standing to respond at all, prudence in each proportionate reply. The vertical axis — the human presence, the humor, the shared dignity — stabilized the field. The agitators had nowhere to go. Their script didn't fit the moment. The field reset. The feast resumed.

This is the Grammar of Agency in the wild: not a technique applied, but a disposition expressed.

Case Study 3: In re Torres Campos, No. D085584 · Cal. Ct. App., Fourth District, Div. One · March 5, 2026

Orientation: The Field

The Taffy Toss and the Buddhist March on Petersburg both demonstrate the Grammar of Agency in real-time human encounters. Torres demonstrates something different and, for our purposes, more urgent: what happens when every human in the chain simultaneously fails to perform the kata. This is the Grammar of Agency in the negative — a controlled demonstration of JPP's complete collapse across an entire professional system, from client to lawyer to opposing counsel to the judicial officer herself.

The field was, on its surface, modest: a post-dissolution dispute over visitation of a dog named Kyra. What entered the field was not malice but something equally corrosive — the comfortable assumption that someone upstream had already done the checking. Munoz found a case citation in a Reddit article and believed it. Bonar received it from her client and cited it without reading it. Torres's counsel drafted a proposed order repeating the fiction and submitted it to the court without verifying it. The commissioner signed it. The hallucination became the record.

What Justice Buchanan's opinion documents is not a single failure of agency but a cascade — each link in the chain outsourcing the discernment function to the link before it, until the chain had no weight-bearing member at all. The Grammar of Agency names this structure precisely. It is Timing Drift at scale: not one agent rushing past the threshold, but an entire system that has quietly removed the timing belt from its architecture.

Part I: The JPP Analysis — Four Moves, Four Failures

The kata of Judgment-Premised Processing runs through four moves in sequence: Frame → Receive and Sense → Orient and Align → [Wu Wei / Timing Belt] → Act and Integrate. In Torres, each move failed — not identically, but with a distinct character specific to each actor's position in the chain. The analysis below runs the kata for the three primary actors: Munoz (the client), Bonar (respondent's counsel), and Torres's counsel (appellant's attorney). The commissioner is addressed separately as a systemic participant.

Move 1: Frame

To Frame is to achieve simultaneous self-awareness and field-awareness — to snap in fully to what is actually happening, not what one anticipated or feared. Framing is the act of properly situating oneself as a moral agent in a specific moment with specific stakes.

MUNOZ <i>Frame: Absent</i>	Munoz received a Reddit article from a paralegal friend and, without pausing to assess the source or the credibility of the citation it contained, accepted 'Marriage of Twigg (1984) 34 Cal.3d 926' as established legal precedent. She did not frame the field: she did not ask who authored the article (a blogger and podcaster), what kind of publication Reddit is, or whether a citation lifted from social media warranted verification before appearing in a court filing. She passed it directly to her attorney as though it were reliable authority. The failure of framing here is acute because Munoz is a layperson — but it is not excused by that status.
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	The Frame move is not a technical legal skill. It is a human act of situational awareness.
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BONAR <i>Frame: Collapsed</i>	Bonar received the Twigg citation from her client and incorporated it into a formal letter to opposing counsel, then into a court opposition, without pausing to ask the most basic framing question: what is this, exactly, and where did it come from? The failure of framing for an attorney is of a categorically different order than for a layperson. Bonar's professional formation — law school, bar admission, the duties enumerated under Cal. Bus. & Prof. Code § 6068 — exists precisely to install the frame: I am an officer of the court; everything I file is my representation of truth to a tribunal. That frame, fully activated, would have stopped the cascade before it began.
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TORRES'S COUNSEL <i>Frame: Externalized</i>	Torres's counsel failed to frame in the most procedurally consequential way: she drafted the proposed Findings and Order After Hearing — the document that would become the court's official ruling — and included the fictional Twigg and Teegarden citations without reading or verifying them. She framed her task as 'transcribe the court's oral ruling into a written order,' rather than 'submit a verified legal document to a tribunal.' These are not the same task. The latter requires the attorney to own every citation in the document as her own representation of law. By externalizing the frame to the opposing party's filings and the court's oral remarks, Torres's counsel effectively removed herself from the field precisely when her presence was most needed.
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Move 2: Receive and Sense

To Receive and Sense is to be actively passive — open to what the moment is delivering before moving to interpret it. The senses gather; the intellect withholds premature judgment. This move requires what the Grammar calls 'the discipline of not rushing to conclusion.' It is the move most directly suppressed by AI-generated fluency.

This is where AI hallucination operates with its most insidious effect. A hallucinated legal citation is designed — not intentionally, but structurally — to defeat the sensing function. It arrives in fluent prose, with proper citation format, plausible party names, a realistic year and reporter, and a holding that fits the argument at hand. It is, in the precise technical sense, specious: it seems true. The sensing function, operating on familiar-looking inputs, registers nothing alarming. The signal that should trigger verification — something feels off — never fires.

The Suppression of Sense in AI-Generated Output

The Grammar of Agency notes that AI 'outputs have form without substance, fluency without accountability.' This is not merely a philosophical observation. In the legal context, it describes a specific mechanism of epistemic failure: the output looks exactly like what real legal research looks like, because

it was trained on real legal research. The difference between a genuine citation and a hallucinated one is not visible in the text itself — it is only accessible through the act of verification, of going to the source. When the sensing function is bypassed — because the form is reassuring — the only remaining safeguard is the deliberate, willed act of checking. That act is precisely what Receive and Sense is designed to prompt.

In Torres, no actor in the chain sensed the disturbance. Munoz sensed authority because the Reddit article was formatted like an article. Bonar sensed authority because her client presented it, and because the citation format was correct. Torres's counsel sensed authority because opposing counsel had cited it and the commissioner had included it in her oral ruling. Each link in the chain received the input through the previous link's apparent verification — a structural illusion of already-performed sensing that had, in fact, never occurred at any link.

Move 3: Orient and Align

To Orient and Align is to turn toward the good — to ask, with deliberate intentionality: what is the right act here, for this person, in this moment, given what is at stake? It is the move of purpose and direction, the alignment of will with the good that conscience identifies.

Here the analysis must be precise about what 'the good' required of each actor. For Munoz, the good required was proportionate care in presenting information to her attorney that would be used in a court proceeding — a duty of minimal responsible citizenship in a legal system. For Bonar, the good required was candor to the tribunal under Cal. Rules of Professional Conduct, Rule 3.3 — an absolute duty to not misrepresent law, which requires verifying what one represents as law. For Torres's counsel, the good required was the same: an attorney drafting a proposed court order bears full professional responsibility for every word in it.

None of these actors failed to orient toward the good in the abstract — none of them intended to deceive, at least initially. The failure of Orient and Align in Torres is subtler: each actor oriented toward a proximate good (win the motion, draft the order efficiently, serve the client) without aligning with the deeper good that professional and moral formation exists to install. The proximate good displaced the categorical good. This is the classic structure of disordered appetite that Aquinas diagnoses in the Summa and the Catechism affirms: the intellect is not broken; it is bent by convenience.

The Bonar Inversion: When Orient and Align Collapse into Self-Defense

The most serious failure of Orient and Align in Torres belongs not to the initial citation of Twigg, but to Bonar's response when Torres's counsel first identified the fiction. At that moment — the second motion to reinstate the appeal — the good was clear: acknowledge the error, correct the record, fulfill the duty of candor. Instead, Bonar doubled down. She filed an opposition asserting the case was 'a legitimate California Supreme Court case, reported at 34 Cal.3d 926, 195 Cal.Rptr. 718, 670 P.2d 340, decided on July 5, 1984.' None of this was true. And unlike the original citation, this additional false information did not come from the Reddit article. It almost certainly came from a second AI query — an attempt to use the machine to defend the machine's first error. This is Orient and Align inverted: the agent has now oriented toward self-protection and away from truth. The disordering of will is now explicit.

The Timing Belt: The Threshold That Was Never Held

Between Orient and Align and Act and Integrate sits the threshold — what the Grammar of Agency calls the wu wei, the timing belt, the active discipline of restraint that holds the discernment open until the act that is ours to perform becomes clear.

Let the tea steep. Gather seeds. Scent tea. Palm seeds. Breathe. Ground.

The timing belt is where Torres is most instructive, because the timing belt was never engaged by any actor at any point. The question the timing belt holds open is precisely the question none of them asked: have I verified this? The tea was never steeped. The seed was never gathered. The space between discernment and action — the space that both Aquinas and Lao Tzu recognized as the locus of genuine moral judgment — was compressed to zero at every node in the chain.

Justice Buchanan's opinion effectively reconstructs the timing belt that the legal system requires — and that human professional formation must install before the moment arrives. The court's observation is worth naming in this register: 'Simply stated, no brief, pleading, motion, or any other paper filed in any court should contain any citations that the attorney responsible for submitting the pleading has not personally read and verified.' This is the institutional grammar of wu wei: a structured pause, a required threshold, a non-negotiable moment of discernment before the act proceeds. What the opinion describes as legal duty, the Grammar of Agency names as the timing belt. They are the same thing.

Move 4: Act and Integrate

To Act and Integrate is to move — now, in this moment — cleanly, with no ripple left. The act is complete when the field has been met and the agent has returned to readiness. The integration is the full-circle closure: the agent assesses, adjusts if necessary, and restores the field.

In Torres, the Act was contaminated at the source. Because no prior move had been performed — no framing, no sensing, no genuine orienting, no threshold held — the acts that followed were, in the Grammar's terms, acts without actus. They had the external form of legal action: letters were written, oppositions filed, orders drafted. But they lacked the interior act — the choosing, the willing, the orienting toward truth — that gives exterior action its moral character.

The integration phase, where the agent assesses and adjusts, is where the failure became irreversible — at least for Bonar. When Torres's counsel identified the fiction and provided Bonar with the opportunity to integrate and correct, Bonar did not integrate. She escalated. She produced additional fictional information and accused opposing counsel of incompetence. The field was not restored. The ripple expanded. The act was never completed in the Thomistic sense, because the agent never stood in truth.

The Commissioner: Systemic Participant

Justice Buchanan's footnote 3 contains the most forward-looking element of the opinion: a recommendation that the Judicial Council consider guidelines requiring verification of citations in proposed orders submitted to the court for signature. This is an institutional acknowledgment that the timing belt must be built into the system's architecture, not merely left to individual professional virtue. The commissioner's failure to verify the citations in the order she signed is not singled out for sanction — Torres's counsel drafted the order. But the modified opinion's addition of Standard 10.80(b)(3) makes clear that judicial officers and court staff who are not themselves using generative AI must nonetheless verify citations submitted to them by counsel. The field cannot hold if the last line of verification has been removed.

Part II: The Redemption Sequence — As Recommended by the Court

The Grammar of Agency's Redemption sequence — Retain, Retrain, Restrain — addresses the structural necessity of moral recovery. Justice Buchanan's opinion is, in its disposition, precisely a Redemption document: it identifies what failed, prescribes what must be recovered, and builds into the institutional record the conditions for restrain. The analysis below applies each move of the sequence to the Torres actors and to the legal system as a structural agent.

Retain: Keep What Is Essential

Retain is the first move of moral recovery because it establishes what is not in question — what the failure did not forfeit. The vertical axis, the categorical commitments of faith, hope, and love in their secular analogs of integrity, duty, and orientation toward the other, is not forfeit by a single failure. Retain is an act of disciplined honesty: the agent identifies what failed and what did not.

Actor	What the failure did NOT forfeit	The court's implicit Retain signal
Bonar	Her license to practice. Her duty of candor — which was not extinguished by its violation but reasserted by its demand. Her professional identity as an officer of the court, which the sanctions process calls her back to, not away from.	<i>The \$5,000 sanction is not disbarment. The referral to the State Bar is not termination. The court names the misconduct precisely and proportionately — serious, not irredeemable.</i>
Torres's Counsel	Her duty to her client. Her standing as an appellate advocate. The forfeiture doctrine applied to her client's claim — not to her ability to practice or argue future cases correctly.	<i>The court imposes no sanction on Torres's counsel — it names her breach, locates it in the forfeiture doctrine, and stops there. The door is left open.</i>

The Legal System	The system of precedent itself — its commitment to consistency, predictability, and adherence to the rule of law — is not invalidated by this episode. It is affirmed by the court's willingness to identify, name, and sanction the distortion.	<i>The court publishes the opinion. It recommends Judicial Council guidelines. It names the problem publicly and calls the system to account without abandoning it.</i>
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Retrain: Modify Behavior by Adjusting

Retrain is the deliberate, patient re-habitation of the capacities that failed — not replacement but adjustment. In the Grammar of Agency's terms, retrain operates at the level of the kata: the agent returns to the specific move that failed and runs it again, slowly, under low-stakes conditions, with the vertical axis engaged and the Influencer community present.

Justice Buchanan's opinion implicitly identifies the precise kata move that requires retraining for each actor. It is the same move in every case, though it presents differently at each node: the timing belt. The threshold between Orient and Align and Act and Integrate — the wu wei, the 'let the tea steep' — was never held by any actor in this chain. Retraining, in both the professional and formational senses, means building the habit of holding that threshold until verification is complete.

'Simply stated, no brief, pleading, motion, or any other paper filed in any court should contain any citations that the attorney responsible for submitting the pleading has not personally read and verified.' — *Noland v. Land of the Free, L.P.* (2025) 114 Cal.App.5th 426, 431, as cited by Buchanan, J.

For Bonar specifically, the retraining imperative is most urgent at the second failure node: the moment when she was confronted with evidence that Twigg was fictitious and chose to generate additional fictional support rather than correct the record. The kata move that failed there was not Frame or Receive and Sense — she received the information clearly enough. It was Orient and Align: she could not, in that moment, orient toward the good of candor because the appetite for self-protection had displaced it. Retraining here is the slow re-habitation of the will — what the CCC calls the discipline of managing appetite by intellect — so that when the confrontation comes again, the move toward truth is reflexive rather than effortful.

The Grammar of Agency notes that wu wei applies to recovery as much as to initial action: retraining cannot be forced. The tea must steep again. For attorneys in the AI era, the practical retraining has a concrete form that Buchanan, J. makes explicit: every citation, in every filing, must be personally read and verified before submission. This is not a burden on top of professional practice. It is professional practice, properly understood. The retraining is the re-installation of a habit that AI fluency has, without any single actor noticing, quietly removed.

The Institutional Retraining: Judicial Council Guidelines

Footnote 3 of the Torres opinion, as amplified by the March 13 modification, is the court's retraining prescription for the legal system as an institution. The recommendation that the Judicial Council adopt guidelines for citation verification — 'particularly those in orders drafted by the parties and submitted to the court for signature' — is an attempt to build the timing belt into procedural architecture rather than leaving it solely to individual professional virtue. Standard 10.80(b)(3), already in effect as of September 1, 2025, requires judicial officers using generative AI to verify outputs. The modified opinion extends this logic: even judicial officers not themselves using AI must verify what counsel puts before them. Retraining the institution means installing the kata at every node.

Restrain: Integrate Prudence as Identity

Restrain does not mean suppress. It means the agent who has failed and retrained now integrates prudence as a structural feature of operation rather than as an occasional corrective. Before the failure, the timing belt may have been understood as a technique, a learned behavior externally applied. After recovery, Restrain means the timing belt has been internalized as identity.

The Grammar of Agency names the paradox at the heart of Restrain: the agent who has passed through moral failure and genuine recovery is, in one specific and irreplaceable sense, more capable than the agent who has not. The recovered agent carries a lived map of their own vulnerabilities. In the Torres context, this means Bonar — if she moves through the full Redemption sequence — emerges knowing, in her body and her professional practice, exactly what it costs to skip the verification step. That knowledge, rightly held, becomes what the Grammar calls prudential capital.

'Honesty in dealing with the courts is of paramount importance, and misleading a judge is, regardless of motives, a serious offense.' — People v. Alvarez (2025) 114 Cal.App.5th 1115, 1119, as cited by Buchanan, J.

The Restrain move, properly integrated, would produce an attorney who does not hold the threshold open because the Rules of Professional Conduct require it — who holds the threshold open because she has lived the cost of failing to. This is the distinction the Grammar draws between technique and disposition. Technique is externally applied; disposition is internally constituted. Formation is the work of converting technique into disposition. The sanction, the State Bar referral, the published opinion — these are not punishments designed to break the agent. They are the field conditions that, if met with genuine retraining, produce the disposition of Restrain.

Synthesis: What Torres Adds to the Grammar

The Taffy Toss demonstrates JPP in a controlled pedagogical setting. The Buddhist March demonstrates JPP in a wild, unscripted human encounter. Torres demonstrates something neither can show: JPP's complete systematic collapse and the institutional architecture that the legal system has built — imperfectly, under pressure — to catch what individual human agency missed.

Three additions to the Grammar emerge from Torres that are worth naming explicitly.

First: **Authority Laundering.** The Grammar identifies Timing Drift — action preceding discernment — as the AI era's primary failure mode. Torres reveals a subtler variant: the outsourcing of discernment upward to an assumed prior authority that has not, in fact, performed it. Each actor in Torres did not feel they were skipping verification; they felt someone upstream had already done it. This is not impatience. It is a structural illusion of already-performed sensing. The Grammar needs this category.

Second: **The Cascade Architecture.** The Grammar's account of the Agent-Influencer-Witness triad maps well onto individual moral moments. Torres shows what happens when the Influencer is not a person, structure, or context, but the output of a system that has no moral standing of its own — and when that output propagates through an entire chain of professional actors without any single agent performing the Witness function. The cascade is not a failure of any one actor's character. It is a systems failure that emerges from the simultaneous absence of the timing belt at every node.

Third: **The Institutional Witness.** The Grammar describes the Witness as the tertiary evaluator who testifies only when systemic disturbance threatens the Agent's autonomy. In Torres, the Witness that finally spoke was not an individual but an institution: the Court of Appeal, in a published opinion, performing the witness function for an entire professional system. Justice Buchanan's recommendation for Judicial Council guidelines is the institutional Witness's act — naming the disturbance and prescribing the conditions for its correction.

Section V. The Dominican Lineage: *Contemplata Aliis Tradere*

The Grammar of Agency does not emerge from abstraction. It emerges from within the Dominican intellectual tradition — the same tradition that produced Thomas Aquinas and animated the Order of Preachers for eight centuries under the principle *contemplata aliis tradere*: share with others the fruits of contemplation.

This is not a slogan. It is a structural commitment: that contemplation and action are not opposed but sequential. The formed agent first receives — in prayer, in study, in community — and then gives. The giving is the mission. But the giving is only possible because the receiving came first. Aquinas did not just study; he prayed before he wrote. This is *wu wei* in Dominican form: the contemplative pause before the proclamation, the interior act completed before the exterior act begins.

St. Hyacinth of Poland embodies this principle with particular force. Six months of formation at Santa Sabina under Dominic himself — and then twenty-five thousand miles on foot across Russia, Sweden, Norway, Prussia, and the Northern nations of Asia. The six months was not insufficient. It was exactly sufficient — because formation is not about the quantity of content transmitted but the quality of disposition formed. Dominic set the gyroscope spinning. It kept spinning through every field disturbance the mission encountered.

Section VI. What the Lay Mission Institute Is For

The Lay Mission Institute exists to form lay missionary disciples — lay persons who carry the Dominican charism of truth-seeking, truth-living, and truth-sharing into the specific fields of their vocations: family, profession, parish, civic life, culture. Not clerics. Not religious. Lay persons, in the world, equipped with the same formation architecture that sent Hyacinth across twenty-five thousand miles.

The Grammar of Agency is an attempt at rendering this formation architecture explicit. It does not add something foreign to the Dominican tradition. It articulates what the tradition has always known and practiced — now enriched by the Taoist wisdom on timing and silence that ancient China has been holding for twenty-six centuries — in terms legible to the contemporary moment.

The capstone claim is simple. The gyroscope must be spinning before the moment arrives. The timing belt must be internalized before the field disturbance. The kata must be in the body before the Witness Moment calls it forward. Because when the moment comes — and it will come, without announcement, when it matters most — no AI will place the Kind bar.

Only the formed human agent can do that.

Section VII:

What If Witness Encounters an Irrational Agent?

Thus far we've introduced a way of thinking about moral action, a structural metaphor based on natural and transcendental virtues moderated by a temporal aspect that probes the field for the precise moment to act. We've spoken of the Witness Moment Triad: the Agent entering the field, the Influencers of that field, and the tertiary Witness discerning disturbance and integrity. But, what about those situations where the Agent loses the ability in the moment to act rationally? Perhaps they are overwhelmed by influences tugging irresistibly at the appetite, or they may be suffering cognitive fatigue, or, they may be so under the influence of passions that they are not really open to reasonable discourse. In such cases, the goal is no longer to influence and reason, but to contain the damage so that others and the irrational agent are not harmed while seeking to regain stability in the field.

Non-Violent, Actively Passive Containment of an Irrational Agent

There are moments when the field ceases to behave like a field — when a human actor enters in a state of irrationality, distortion, or interior collapse so severe that ordinary influence no longer functions. In such moments, the operator cannot rely on persuasion, dialogue, or shared rational ground. The task is no longer to shape the field but to contain it — non-violently, proportionately, and without surrendering agency.

Containment is not domination. It is not force. It is not argument. It is a non-violent, actively passive stance: a disciplined resistance that prevents further harm while preserving the dignity of all involved.

The Containment Stance: Three Moves

Still the Field. The operator reduces motion, noise, and escalation. This is wu wei in its purest form: do nothing that adds force to the moment. Stillness is not withdrawal. It is the active removal of fuel.

Hold the Boundary. The operator becomes a living perimeter — a stabilizing presence that prevents the irrational agent from expanding the disturbance. Calm tone, slow movements, proportionate distance, non-reactive posture, refusal to mirror the irrationality. The operator becomes the yoke.

Absorb Without Internalizing. The irrational agent may project, accuse, distort, or lash out verbally. The operator receives the impact without letting it penetrate the vertical axis. Temperance (no reactive excess), Fortitude (no collapse), Prudence (no premature action), Justice (no dehumanization). The operator becomes the stabilizer.

The Timing Belt Under Maximum Load

Containment is where the timing belt earns its name. The irrational agent is operating in wei — forced action, distorted timing. Containment requires wu wei — disciplined non-forcing.

Let the tea steep. Breathe. Ground. Hold.

This is not delay. It is temporal integrity under pressure — tensegrity expressed through non-forcing.

Why Containment Is Not Coercion

Coercion overrides agency. Containment protects agency — the operator's, the Witness's, and even the irrational agent's. Coercion says: I will force you. Containment says: I will not let this moment collapse. Coercion escalates. Containment stabilizes. Coercion violates dignity. Containment preserves it. Containment, too, is a Witness Moment: the operator embodies agency so that the field does not collapse.

Conclusion: The Recovery of Human Agency

We are living through a transformation unprecedented in human history: a world in which artificial systems increasingly mediate perception, shape attention, and execute tasks that once required human judgment. The danger is not that machines will become moral agents. It is that human beings, habituated to outsourcing discernment, will forget how to be.

The Grammar of Agency is offered as a counter-movement — a recovery of the interior stance that makes moral action possible. It is not a technique, nor a theory, nor a set of rules. It is a formation architecture: a way of shaping the human person so that when the moment arrives, the act arises from character rather than convenience.

The system is tensegrity. Catholic Social Teaching provides altitude. JPP provides motion. Wu wei provides timing. The gyroscope provides stability. The Agent-Influencer-Witness triad provides relational geometry. The Witness Moment provides ignition.

Artificial intelligence will continue to shape the field. It will process, predict, and propose. But it cannot stand in the Witness Moment. It cannot bear responsibility. It cannot choose the good. Only a human being can do that.

The task ahead is therefore not to resist technology, but to form agents who can remain human within it — agents whose gyroscopes are spinning, whose stabilizers are active, whose timing belts hold, whose dispositions are tuned, and whose presence is real. The future will belong to those who can hold the threshold open long enough for discernment to complete its work.

The person who has been formed will meet the moment.

The person who has not been formed will reach for the taffy.

The Grammar of Agency exists to form the person who places the Kind bar and waits.

Glossary of CST-JPP Terms

This Glossary is the Rosetta Stone for the Grammar of Agency: it defines the core terms phenomenologically, in the moment of the moral act, providing operators with a shared vocabulary for navigating moral moments with clarity and integrity.

Actus. The decisive, embodied action taken by the Agent. The hinge between intention and consequence. The only moment where agency is real.

Agent. The human moral actor who performs actus. Carries the vertical axis (faith, hope, love) and is solely responsible for action unless autonomy is overridden.

Con+Facere. To make with. The moral moment is formed by the Agent, the Influencer(s), and the Witness. Formation is always communal.

CST Fourfold Test. The altitude instrument: Does this restore human dignity? Seed the common good? Strengthen brotherhood and sisterhood? Uplift the little ones?

Four Moves (JPP Kata). Frame — Receive and Sense — Orient and Align — [Wu Wei / Timing Belt] — Act and Integrate. The repeatable kata that forms disposition through praxis.

Horizontal Plane (Virtue Matrix). The stabilizing field of the cardinal virtues: Prudence, Justice, Fortitude, Temperance. LLM-legible but insufficient alone.

Influencer. Any force — person, system, structure, or context — that shapes the field in which the Agent acts. Does not act in the Agent's place.

JPP (Judgment-Premised Processing). The steering mechanism — a kata for navigating chaotic moments with clarity and proportion. A discipline for prudential praxis, not a system for judging people.

Tensegrity. Structural stability through dynamic balance of tension and compression. The architecture holds under load not through rigidity but through balanced forces.

Threshold. the liminal space between Orient & Align and Act & Integrate.

Timing Drift — the failure mode where action precedes discernment, often due to misreading the field rather than failure of character.

Vertical Axis (Transcendent Spine). Faith, Hope, Love — the human-only virtues. Cannot be computed or automated. Orient the Agent toward meaning, purpose, and moral depth.

Witness. The tertiary evaluator who reads the moral vector of the moment. Testifies only when systemic disturbance threatens the Agent's autonomy. If autonomy is intact, the Witness remains silent.

Witness Moment. The instant of actus when the Agent penetrates the horizontal plane and the vertical axis enters the world. Where the wind hits the sail. Where action becomes testimony.

Wu Wei (Timing Belt). From the classical Taoist tradition of ancient China: Lao Tzu, Tao Te Ching (6th c. BCE, Zhou dynasty); Zhuangzi (4th c. BCE). The discipline of active restraint between Orient and Align and Act and Integrate — holding the threshold open while discernment completes its interior work before the exterior act begins. The temporal complement to Aquinas's *recta ratio agibilium*: where Aquinas gives the what of right judgment, wu wei gives the when. Mantra: Let the tea steep. Gather seeds. Scent tea. Palm seeds. Breathe. Ground.

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